

Wi-Fi access points often have their status as “open”. Novice users often initiate the network procedures without realising that other people could be latching onto their computer, thereby gain access to their wireless LAN and browsing the internet for free – or worse, stealing data. The most common wireless encryption standard WEP (Wired Equivalent Publicity) and even the WPA and WPA2 Wi-Fi Protected Access can be broken. Unencrypted devices are certainly at major risk, but so are protected ones. Open networks can also be monitored so user data can be witnessed and copied.

We have also earlier mentioned the extent to which the 2.4 GHz spectrum channel is overcrowded, with so many wireless technologies utilising it. Other technologies using this spectrum include systems such as Bluetooth.

Another term you will come across is Wi-Fi pollution – this is used to describe an excess number of access points in an area, especially on the same channel. This can cause reduced

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bandwidth, more infrequent connectivity, lower signal-to-noise ratios, and can be a serious problem. In a large apartment / work complex, there could be a large number of Wi-Fi access points, along with parallel crowding of Bluetooth, microwave ovens,

security cameras and the like. The general advice for those who suffer from interference is to migrate the Wi-Fi connectivity to the 5 GHz spectrum, parts of which are also unlicensed.

Workshop: Enabling Wi-Fi on your computer

Now, if you have bought your computer recently, or have a laptop, chances are that you have Wi-Fi access. Microsoft Windows, for example, has comprehensive driver-level support for Wi-Fi, the quality of which depends on the specific hardware manufacturer. Most hardware vendors ship the default Windows drivers along with their products. Earlier versions of Windows, such as 98, ME and 2000 do not have built-in support for Wi-Fi drivers. So, if you possess one of the older versions, you will need to get the software from the manufacturer, most often by